Insight.

AI-Powered Prospective Student Experience

Turning website friction into guided conversations

Prepared for Murdoch University | March 2026

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Today's Agenda

01 — The Challenge

What the research tells us about the prospective student journey

02 — The Solution

A working AI agent built for Murdoch, ready to demo

03 — From PoC to Production

Federating knowledge and building a platform

04 — The Strategic Case

Why this matters commercially and architecturally

05 — Why Now

The window for first-mover advantage

06 — The Roadmap

A phased engagement from pilot to scale

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The Challenge

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Your Website Is Working Against Your Enrolment Funnel

The split students feel but can't see

The site is divided between two sub-sites with different owners and different agendas — students bear the cost of that division.

Invisible seams, real confusion

Students cross between these environments without knowing it — hitting inconsistent layouts, different terminology, content never written for them.

Study sub-site — Marketing-owned

Conversion-focused and brand-consistent — but covers only part of the picture.

The structural result

Navigation that maps to Murdoch's internal ownership structure — not how a prospective student thinks about their choices.

Explore sub-site — School/Faculty-owned

Deep course content — but every school maintains it differently. No unified voice or student-facing logic.

Every unanswered question

Erodes confidence in Murdoch. That erosion is structural, not incidental.

[Insert: side-by-side Study vs Explore page — annotated with ownership labels]

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Three Cohorts, One Problem

COHORT 01

School Leavers

Comparing 3–5 institutions under real time pressure. Want instant answers. When the site doesn't respond immediately, they move on — and the next university that answers them wins.

ATAR queries | Scholarships | First year

COHORT 02

Mature-Age Students

Returning after a career or life break. Carry specific anxieties about belonging and whether prior experience counts. The site treats them the same as school leavers — no signal Murdoch understands their situation.

Belonging | Eligibility | RPL

COHORT 03

Growth Learners

International students and career changers navigating complex pathway information scattered across disconnected pages. High cognitive load, high-stakes decision.

Credit recognition | Pathways | Visas

[Insert: journey map showing drop-off points between awareness and enquiry stages]

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This Cohort Has Already Moved On From Your Website

2 in 3

prospective students prefer AI-powered search over Google when researching universities

Everspring, 2025 — 450,000+ student search sessions

4% → 23%

high school seniors using AI to research universities (2023 → 2025)

Carnegie College Choice Trends Report, 2025 — six-fold growth in two years

IMPLICATION **What This Means for Murdoch**

Education is the **second-highest category** for traffic referred by AI tools — behind only online services.

This cohort is not waiting for universities to catch up. They are already asking AI what Murdoch offers, how to get in, and how it compares.

The question is whether Murdoch's answers are the ones being surfaced.

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The Solution

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What We've Built

A working AI agent — built on Claude Sonnet, trained on Murdoch-specific content — that answers the questions prospective students are actually asking, at the moment they need answers.

[Murdoch AI agent prototype — chat interface screenshot]

Show a realistic exchange: student asking about entry requirements or course options with agent response visible

Real-time Streams responses across courses, pathways, fees, entry requirements, and campus life

Adaptive Responds differently to school leavers vs mature-age students — cohort-aware

Contextual Maintains conversation context — students don't repeat themselves

Actionable Surfaces next steps: application links, tour bookings, advisor handoff

On-brand Deployed within the Murdoch brand system — looks and sounds like Murdoch

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Live Demonstration

Walking through a live session — showing how the agent handles the queries your prospective students are actually asking.

School leaver · Mature-age · Course discovery · Entry requirements

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03

From PoC to Production

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A Knowledge Platform, Not a Chatbot

The prototype draws from a curated knowledge base. The production platform connects to authoritative source systems — live data, governed access, no manual updates required.

Source System	What It Enables
Course Management	Live catalogue, units, prerequisites, fees
Admissions / SMS	Entry requirements, ATAR cutoffs, application status
Scholarship Database	Eligibility criteria, deadlines, award amounts
RPL / Credit Transfer	Prior learning rules, credit mapping
International Office	Visa pathways, English requirements, CRICOS
Events & Campus	Open days, tours, orientation, accommodation

[Architecture diagram]
Data sources → Knowledge Platform → Agent

Three-layer diagram. No vendor logos. Murdoch brand colours.

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Production-Grade From Day One

01

Conversation Design

Formalised cohort flows, escalation triggers, brand voice governance, and full accessibility compliance.

Cohort flows | Escalation | WCAG 2.1 AA

02

Integration Layer

CRM write-back for lead capture, application system connection, live advisor handoff with full context passed.

CRM | Applications | Bookings

03

Quality & Governance

Grounded responses with source citations, hallucination detection, Privacy Act compliance, sensitive topic escalation.

Citations | PII | Audit trail

04

Analytics Engine

Real-time dashboard, content gap detection, funnel attribution (chat → application → enrolment), A/B testing.

Dashboard | Gaps | Attribution

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04

The Strategic Case

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One Capability, Two Strategic Lenses

MARKETING

The Marketing & Conversion Case

Murdoch's marketing investment drives traffic to a website that loses prospects before they convert. Every dollar spent on brand, search, and social is partially wasted at the point of information-seeking.
The AI agent is a **conversion layer** — it captures intent at peak engagement and converts it into action.
When a prospective student gets a clear, confident answer at 10pm on a Sunday while filling out a comparison spreadsheet, that matters. **The competitor who answers first wins the consideration set.**
Every question asked is a signal about what students don't understand, where the narrative breaks down, what content is missing. That feedback loop is currently invisible. The agent makes it explicit.

ARCHITECTURE

The Architecture & Platform Case

This is not a bolt-on chatbot. The architecture is built for institutional scale:

- **Model-agnostic API layer** — updated as capabilities improve without rebuilding
- **Separated knowledge layer** — content teams update without engineering involvement
- **Integration-ready** — CRM, application systems, and advisor queues via standard APIs
- **Audit trail built in** — conversation logging for compliance and performance review
- **Flexible deployment** — embedded widget, standalone page, or mobile-first interface
- **Murdoch-owned architecture** — no vendor lock-in

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Why Now

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The Window Is Open — Briefly

DEMAND

Students Already Expect It

2 in 3 prospective students prefer AI-powered search over Google (Everspring, 2025). Six-fold growth in two years. This cohort is already asking AI about Murdoch.

TIMING

Technology Is Ready

Twelve months ago this was genuinely difficult. The models, infrastructure, and integration patterns have matured. The risk of early adoption has dropped substantially.

MARKET

Competitors Are Moving

Leading Australian universities are actively piloting AI student experience tools. The question is whether Murdoch leads that shift in WA or responds to it.

READINESS

Research Is Done

UX audit, user interviews, journey mapping — already complete. The path from insight to implementation is unusually short.

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The Roadmap

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Phased Engagement Roadmap

Lane	**Phase 1 — Prove** Weeks 1–8	**Phase 2 — Federate** Weeks 9–20	**Phase 3 — Scale** Ongoing
Knowledge	Build knowledge base from Murdoch website & course content	Connect admissions, scholarships & RPL data sources	Live data feeds & continuous updates
Agent	Deploy production agent to staging environment	Multi-cohort conversation flows & personalisation	Full journey coverage & authenticated access
Integration	Advisor handoff protocol for complex queries	CRM integration & lead capture pipeline	Booking systems & application tracking
Operations	Analytics dashboard & baseline metrics	Staff training & escalation workflows	Continuous improvement & A/B testing loop
	▲ Pilot Live	▲ Full Cohort Coverage	▲ Continuous Optimisation

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From Pilot to Platform

8 WEEKS Phase 1 — Prove

Focus: Highest-friction section of the prospective student journey. Website and course system as knowledge sources.

Deliverables:

- Production agent deployed to staging
- Knowledge base from Murdoch content
- Analytics dashboard: volume, topics, escalations
- Advisor handoff protocol

School leavers | Course discovery | Entry requirements

10–12 WEEKS Phase 2 — Federate

Focus: Connect admissions, scholarships, and RPL data sources. Expand to mature-age and international cohorts.

Deliverables:

- Federated knowledge platform (4 source systems)
- CRM integration & lead capture pipeline
- Multi-cohort conversation coverage
- Staff training & escalation workflows

All cohorts | CRM | Admissions & RPL

ONGOING Phase 3 — Scale

Focus: Full prospective journey coverage. Authenticated access for returning applicants. Booking integrations.

Deliverables:

- Full production platform
- Application tracking integration
- Campus booking integration
- Optimisation loop from live conversation data

Full journey | Bookings | Multi-language

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A Clear Commitment to a Defined Scope

FROM US

What We Bring

- AI product expertise and a track record of deployment at institutional scale
- Established integration patterns for university systems (admissions, CRM, LMS)
- A working prototype — not a proposal, a product ready to demonstrate today
- Research evidence that makes this evidence-led from day one
- An architecture that Murdoch owns and controls

Expertise | Prototype | Evidence

FROM YOU

What We're Asking For

A commitment to Phase 1:

- Eight weeks
- Defined scope: course discovery & entry requirements, school leaver cohort
- Shared success criteria agreed upfront: engagement rates, conversion indicators, advisor deflection
- Access to course content and admissions data for knowledge base construction

This is not a multi-year transformation program. It is eight weeks to prove the concept works — with Murdoch's students, on Murdoch's website, with Murdoch's data.

Phase 1 | 8 weeks | Defined scope

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Your students are arriving curious and leaving confused. We've built an AI agent that turns that friction into a conversation — and we're ready to prove it works.

The question isn't whether this becomes standard. It's whether Murdoch leads.

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Let's Talk

We're ready to walk through Phase 1 scoping, answer technical questions, and agree on next steps today.

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Research Evidence Summary

APPENDIX A

Source	Key Finding
UX Audit	Navigation maps to internal org structure, not student mental models. Core information consistently difficult to locate.
UX Audit	Study sub-site (Marketing) and Explore sub-site (Schools) operate as separate environments — inconsistent layouts, terminology, depth. Students hit a jarring drop in coherence when crossing between them.
UX Audit	Mobile experience falls significantly below expectation for a primarily mobile-first cohort.
School Leaver Research	Students compare 3–5 institutions simultaneously. Whoever answers their question first, clearly, wins.
School Leaver Research	Interviewees expressed clear preference for immediate, conversational answers. One participant named AI as their preferred channel over live chat and email — consistent with broader industry research.
Everspring (2025)	2 in 3 prospective students prefer AI-powered search over Google. Education is 2nd highest category for AI-referred traffic. (450,000+ search sessions analysed)
Carnegie (2025)	High school seniors using AI to research universities: 4% (2023) → 23% (2025). Six-fold growth in two years.
Mature-Age Research	Site does not signal that Murdoch understands returning students' specific circumstances or anxieties.
Growth Learner Research	Pathway information is fragmented across disconnected pages. High cognitive load, high-stakes decision.
Journey Map	Multiple drop-off points between awareness and enquiry — each a recoverable conversion currently being lost.

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Architecture Overview

APPENDIX B

LAYER 1 Data Sources

- Course Management System
- Admissions / Student Management
- Scholarship Database
- RPL / Credit Transfer
- International Office Systems
- Events & Campus Services
- CRM (Salesforce / Dynamics)

Course Mgmt · Admissions · Scholarships · CRM

LAYER 2 Knowledge Platform

- Content ingestion & chunking
- Semantic embedding & retrieval
- Governance & confidence thresholds
- Audit trail & logging
- Content team updates *(no engineering required)*

Ingest · Embed · Retrieve · Govern

LAYER 3 Agent Interface

- Conversation engine
- Cohort detection & adaptation
- Response streaming
- Escalation logic
- Analytics & reporting

Integration: CRM write-back · Advisor handoff · Booking systems · Application tracking

Converse · Adapt · Escalate · Analyse

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